Unit – 6 Professional Ethics

6.1 Concept of Ethics

- The term ethics is derived from the Greek word ethos which means character.
- Ethics is a major branch of philosophy.
- Ethics is a fix code of conduct.
- Our action and reaction to a particular idea builds our system of ethics.
- Simple meaning of ethics is protecting Right and avoiding Wrong.
- Having ethics is a sign of good understanding and maturity.

6.2 Importance of Ethics in Life

Engineering ethics is not only teaching moral behaviour in knowing about immoral and amoral in a set of beliefs, but also increasing the ability of engineers and other professionals to face boldly with the moral problems arising from technological advancements, changes and other related activities. With the use of ethical theories we can solve

1. It helps to understanding moral dilemmas.
2. Ethics is necessary for justifying professional obligations.
4. It is the core element to develop a sustainable career.
5. Knowledge and implementation of ethic helps to be a good corporate citizen.
6. It helps a lot to be able to take an ethical decision.
7. Ethics creates a win win situation in professional life.
8. It is there to inculcate nobility.
9. Conduct of ethics makes one a reliable and responsible professional.
10. Ethics helps on to find the best possible solution of any problem.

6.3 Principles of Ethics

Ethical principles are universal standard of right and wrong prescribing the kind of behaviour in an ethical company or person should and should not engage in. these principles provide a guide to making decisions but they also establish the criteria by which your decision will be judged by others.

We can divide principles of Ethics in personal and professional ethics.

Principles of Personal Ethics	Principles of Professional Ethics
It is also known as morality	It is known as code of conduct at workplace
Concern for the well-being of others	It closely connected with loyalty
Respect for the autonomy of the others	Integrity with other coworkers is important
Trustworthiness and honesty	As a professional one has to keep a promise
Compliance with the law	To be law abided is the prime concern here
Refusing to take unfair advantages	Be skillful and work with 100% commitment
Preventing harm to anyone	Work and responsibility becomes your accountability

6.4 Engineering Ethics

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Engineering ethics aims at knowing moral values related to engineering, finding accurate solutions to the moral problems in engineering and justifying moral judgments of engineering.

Engineering Ethics gives a total view of the moral problems and how to solve these issues specifically related to engineering field.

Engineering ethics also concerns with discovering moral principles such as obligation, rights and ideals in engineering and by applying them to take a correct decision.

It talks about a clear awareness of the experimental nature of any project. An engineer has to also be careful about its possible side effects and be accountable for the results of project.

6.5 Understanding and Resolving Ethical Dilemmas

Ethical (moral) dilemma as are situations in which moral reasons come in to conflict, or in which the applications of moral values are unclear, and it is not immediately obvious what should be done. Ethical dilemma as arise in engineering, as elsewhere, because moral values are many and varied and can make competing claims.

Yet, although moral dilemma as comprise the most difficult occasions for moral reasoning, they constitute a relatively small percentage of *moral choices, that is, decisions* involving moral values.

A) Moral clarity: Identify the relevant moral values –identifying moral values and reasons in the situation

b) Conceptual clarity: Be clear about key concepts –be clear about the conceptual issues involved. What you are asked to do may not be good for the organization in long run

c) Informed about the facts: Obtain relevant information. This means gathering information that is pertinent in light of the applicable moral values

d) Informed about the options: Consider all (realistic) options. Initially, ethical dilemmas seem to force us in to a two way choice: Do this or do that. Either bow to a supervisor's orders or blow the whistle to the town authorities. A closer look of ten reveals additional options.

e) Well reasoned: Make a reasonable decision. Arrive at a carefully reasoned judgment by weighing all the relevant moral reasons and facts. This is not a mechanical process that a computer or algorithm might do for us. Instead, it is a deliberation aimed at integrating all the relevant reasons, facts, and values in a morally reasonable manner. If there is no ideal solution, as is often the case, we seek a satisfactory one, what Herbert Simon dubbed "satisfying."

f) Balance Sheet approach: In this approach one has to write down pros and cons of the decision. This gives a clear picture of the things and help to arrive at a best decision.

6.6 Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR)

Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) is a mechanism by which companies hold themselves to a set of legal, ethical, social and ecological standards. The term was coined in the 1950s, although the real impetus came later on after a number of industrial disasters, such as the 1969 Santa Barbara oil spill, which led to low public confidence in businesses and translated into massive public protests. It is a form of business self-regulation that has developed alongside greater public awareness of ethical and environmental issues. It is generally understood to be a mechanism whereby companies take responsibility for the impacts of their decisions and practices by holding themselves to a set of ethical, social and ecological standards — with the aim of contributing towards the health, welfare and sustainable development of society.

CSR is important as it represent a major competitive advantage for a company for the following reasons:

Improved brand perception: CSR can have a positive impact on the perception of an organisation's brand, as well as the organization's overall reputation.

Boosted morale for employees: CSR practices help boost employee morale as employees and employers gain a greater sense of purpose in their work.

Improved customer loyalty: Customers value CSR and companies that invest in it will likely have higher customer retention and loyalty.

Greater competitive advantage: Companies that are socially responsible are more likely to obtain a competitive advantage in the marketplace due to superior brand recognition and the ability to attract and retain the best staff.

Today, people do not just expect companies to be socially responsible, ethical, transparent and inclusive—they demand it. CSR is a symbol of success as well as duty to clients and fellow citizens.